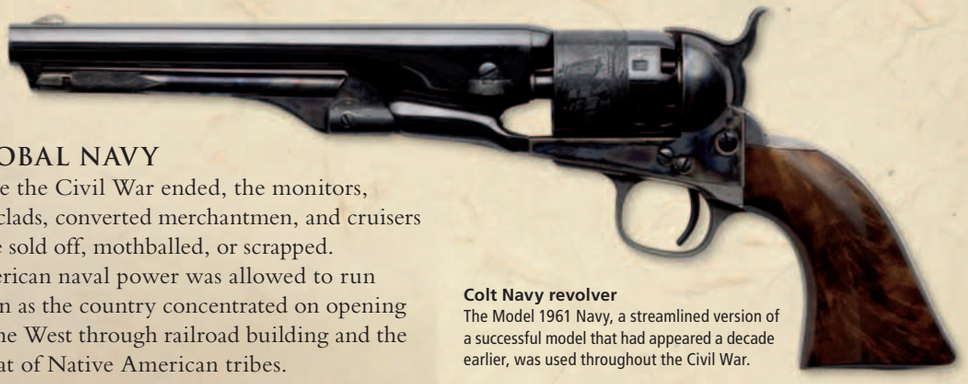


Armored ironclads, monitors, and river paddle steamers fought one another in coastal waters and along the Mississippi. The South bought cruisers from British shipyards to act as commerce raiders and used them to great effect. It deployed tethered mines, "torpedo boats" with explosive devices on long spars, and proto-submarines such as the *Hunley*, which sank the steam sloop *Housatonic* in Charleston Harbor in February 1864. But the naval dominance of the North was never seriously challenged.



Colt Navy revolver
The Model 1961 Navy, a streamlined version of a successful model that had appeared a decade earlier, was used throughout the Civil War.

GLOBAL NAVY

Once the Civil War ended, the monitors, ironclads, converted merchantmen, and cruisers were sold off, mothballed, or scrapped. American naval power was allowed to run down as the country concentrated on opening up the West through railroad building and the defeat of Native American tribes.

In 1879, when the United States considered intervening in the War of the Pacific between Chile and Peru, it was unable to do so because it had no warships to match Chile's British-supplied battleships. Yet the rapid growth of American industry was creating the technological and financial basis for a major fleet and for overseas imperial expansion. In 1883 Congress authorized the building of the United States' first three steel cruisers, the starting point for an accelerating program that would create the New Navy. An ideology for this modern force was supplied by historian Alfred Thayer Mahan, who argued that naval power was the key to global domination and thus essential for the United States if it was to take its rightful place among the world's great powers.

When the United States went to war with Spain in 1898, a conflict triggered by an accidental explosion on board the US battleship *Maine* in Havana Harbor, it gave the New Navy a chance to flex its muscles against distinctly inferior European opposition. After crushing victories at Manila Bay and off Cuba, the United States came out of the war with a permanent involvement in the Philippines and a string of island bases for its Pacific fleet, as well as assured dominance in the Caribbean. When President Teddy Roosevelt sent the "Great White Fleet" to show the Star and Stripes on a world tour in 1907, it included 16 battleships. The United States had arrived as a serious naval power.

